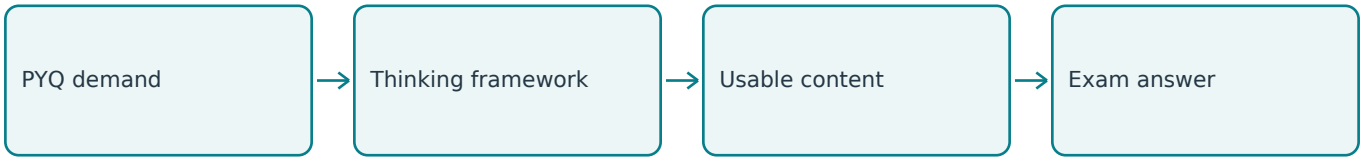
START HERE

International Relations

UPSC CSE MAINS • GS II • Preparation and answer writing

Understand the relationship. Explain the mechanism. Make a reasoned judgement.

A framework-led guide for Sravanthi



What is inside

A 2013-2026 IR demand map; observations from two topper practice copies; country and theme notes; maps and reproducible diagrams; six worked answers; and a 21-day recall-and-writing plan.

Scope: General Studies IR. Since your optional is Mathematics, this guide keeps theory limited to ideas that improve GS answers.
Prepared: 2 November 2026. Examples carry dates where needed. The update bank is selective; it is not an exhaustive record of every development in 2026.
How to read: Start with the frameworks, then learn each country as interests, cooperation, friction and response. After every page, close it and recall five points.
Questions in the PYQ tables are concise paraphrases. Model answers, flowcharts and assessments are original teaching material, not official UPSC solutions.

Sources and verification notes are at the end.

START HERE

Your route through the guide

Use the content in three passes

You do not need to memorise every line. Build a small set of reusable explanations and attach country-specific examples.

Pass	What you should produce
1. Understand	Read the syllabus and frameworks. Explain national interest, strategic autonomy, maritime security and global governance in your own words.
2. Retrieve	Turn each country/theme page into one recall card: 3 interests + 3 examples + 2 problems + 2 responses + 1 visual.
3. Write	Attempt a PYQ without notes; compare its demands with your headings; improve the weakest paragraph.

Navigation

The clickable contents below take you to each major part. PDF bookmarks also follow the chapter titles.

Syllabus and recurring demands • 2013-2026 PYQ map • Topper-copy lessons • Thinking frameworks
Neighbourhood and China • Major powers and regions • Groupings and institutions
Diaspora and cross-cutting themes • Worked answers • Revision and practice

A 30-minute session

8 min understand one page → 5 min closed-book recall → 5 min draw one diagram/map → 10 min outline or write one answer → 2 min note one correction.

Minimum material to retain

For each theme: one clear definition, two causal chains, three examples, one limitation and one practical way forward. Add data only when it improves the argument.

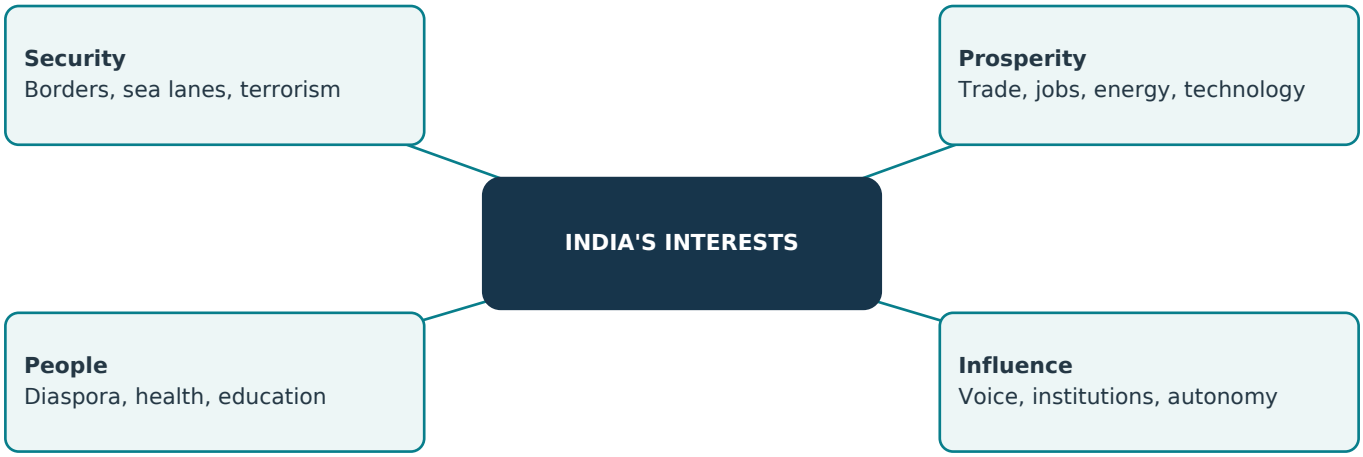
SYLLABUS

The syllabus becomes four tasks

Read the demand before choosing the framework

Syllabus area	What UPSC can ask	Your preparation unit
India and neighbours	Why a neighbour matters; domestic politics; China; water, borders and connectivity.	One page per neighbour + one regional map.
Bilateral/regional/global arrangements	What a partnership delivers; why it is constrained; whether it complements another forum.	Purpose → instruments → results → limits.
External policies and diaspora	How tariffs, wars, migration rules or technology restrictions affect India.	Policy → transmission channel → Indian impact → response.
International institutions	Structure/mandate; performance; power and funding; reforms that India needs.	Mandate → tools → record → gap → feasible reform.

The national-interest lenses



Use selectively: A water-diplomacy answer may need federal politics and ecology. An IPMDA answer needs information, enforcement and maritime capacity. Do not force all lenses into every question.

The question behind most IR questions

What changes India's room to act, and what should India do about it? Answer this only after meeting the exact words of the question.

[Q] UPSC syllabus and GS II papers.

What the PYQs repeatedly test

A qualitative reading of 2013-2026

Recurring cluster	Selected PYQ trail	Preparation lesson
Maritime geography and rivalry	2013 ports; 2014 South China Sea; 2020 Quad; 2021 AUKUS; 2024 Maldives; 2026 IPMDA/BRI.	Join geography to trade, security and local agency.
Institutions and reform	2013 IMF/World Bank; 2014/16/18 WTO; 2015 UNSC; 2020 WHO; 2023 IMO; 2024 CTC; 2025 UN.	Learn mandates and test performance against them.
Diversifying partnerships	Japan 2013/19; Africa 2015/21/25; Central Asia 2018/24; I2U2 2022.	Show complementary interests and delivery gaps.
People and changing world order	Diaspora 2017/20/23/26; India's role 2019; US-China 2021; sovereign nationalism 2025.	Connect social/economic links to power, with limits.

The 2026 paper makes the method clear

- IPMDA: **mechanism plus critical assessment**, rather than a list of Quad summits.
- BRICS: **representation and alternatives**, with institutional limits.
- Diaspora: **conversion of networks into influence**; distinguish potential from guaranteed support.
- BRI: **India's security and regional influence**; both demands require separate treatment.

How to use this analysis

These are preparation priorities, not a prediction formula. Several themes overlap, so this guide does not present misleadingly precise theme-frequency percentages.

The next four pages cover 61 core IR questions under the stated classification. GS II questions primarily about domestic governance or constitutional comparison are excluded, even when they mention another country.

[Q13-Q26] Yearly papers; [IDX] topic index used for discovery.

PYQ map • 2013-2014

Paraphrased demands • use the original paper for exact wording

Year / Q	Marks	Question focus	What your answer must do
2013 / 18	10	Afghanistan after the proposed ISAF withdrawal	Regional risks → Indian stakes → safeguards
2013 / 19	10	String of Pearls and India's response	Location → dual-use risk → response
2013 / 20	10	India-Japan economic ties below potential	Potential → specific policy constraints
2013 / 21	10	Bangladesh's Shahbag divisions: significance for India	Domestic divide → cross-border effects
2013 / 22	10	Maldives political developments and Indian concerns	Political change → maritime/strategic stakes
2013 / 23	10	Domestic influences on India-Sri Lanka relations	Tamil politics/fisheries → foreign-policy choices
2013 / 24	10	Gujral Doctrine and continuing relevance	Principles → applications → limits
2013 / 25	10	World Bank versus IMF	Mandate, financing, instruments and distinction
2014 / 16	12.5	South China Sea tensions and India-China issues	Navigation → wider rivalry → Indian stakes
2014 / 17	12.5	Information Technology Agreements and India	Tariff reduction → gains and domestic industry costs
2014 / 18	12.5	Aid tied to donor-country procurement	Finance/quality gains versus autonomy/value costs
2014 / 19	12.5	NDB versus AIIB: significance for India	Institutional comparison → finance and influence
2014 / 20	12.5	WTO mandate, binding effect and food security	Rules/enforcement → India's food-security case

Do not answer an old political situation as though it is current. Use the PYQ to learn its reasoning pattern, then update the example.

Yearly sources: [Q13], [Q14].

PYQ map • 2015-2017

Paraphrased demands • use the original paper for exact wording

Year / Q	Marks	Question focus	What your answer must do
2015 / 17	12.5	India's growing engagement with Africa	Gains → constraints → partnership quality
2015 / 18	12.5	Obstacles to India's permanent UNSC seat	Power, regional rivalries and Charter hurdle
2015 / 19	12.5	Project Mausam and its strategic dimension	Maritime heritage → trust → strategic relevance
2015 / 20	12.5	Soft power and India-Pakistan distrust	Goodwill channels → evidence → security limits
2016 / 17	12.5	Doha Round differences and Indian interests	Agriculture/development → bargaining conflict
2016 / 18	12.5	Look East after the Cold War	Economic and strategic dimensions
2016 / 19	12.5	Terrorism, Pakistan and SAARC's future	Bilateral conflict → institutional paralysis
2016 / 20	12.5	UNESCO MacBride Commission and India	Information imbalance → communication equity
2017 / 9	10	China's economic weight and military power	Economic capacity → strategic effects on India
2017 / 10	10	ECOSOC and its functional commissions	Functions + correct institutional examples
2017 / 19	15	Energy cooperation with West Asia	Supply, investment, routes and diversification
2017 / 20	15	Indian diaspora in Southeast Asia	Economic + social contributions; varied contexts

Do not answer an old political situation as though it is current. Use the PYQ to learn its reasoning pattern, then update the example.

Yearly sources: [Q15], [Q16], [Q17].

PYQ map • 2018-2020

Paraphrased demands • use the original paper for exact wording

Year / Q	Marks	Question focus	What your answer must do
2018 / 9	10	Deepening India-Israel relationship	Breadth of sectors + reasons for durability
2018 / 10	10	Central Asia and the Ashgabat Agreement	Connectivity and competing external powers
2018 / 19	15	WTO reforms amid trade wars	Reform areas → India's development interests
2018 / 20	15	US-Iran nuclear dispute: impact and response	Sanctions → energy/connectivity → choices
2019 / 9	10	India-Japan strategic/global partnership	Bilateral cooperation → Asian/global effects
2019 / 10	10	UNESCO funding and political tensions	Institutional dependence → politicisation
2019 / 19	15	India's changing identity in global order	Evaluate the premise using continuity and change
2019 / 20	15	India-US friction and Indian ambitions	Convergence → autonomy-related divergences
2020 / 9	10	WHO during COVID-19	Mandate → contribution → failures → reform
2020 / 10	10	Diaspora in US/European politics and economies	Networks/examples → influence → limits
2020 / 19	15	Quad's changing role	Evaluate the premise; distinguish bloc/alliance/forum
2020 / 20	15	US versus Russian defence ties; Indo-Pacific	Compare value, dependencies and strategic effects

Do not answer an old political situation as though it is current. Use the PYQ to learn its reasoning pattern, then update the example.

Yearly sources: [Q18], [Q19], [Q20].

PYQ map • 2021-2023

Paraphrased demands • use the original paper for exact wording

Year / Q	Marks	Question focus	What your answer must do
2021 / 9	10	India's influence in Africa	Instruments, outcomes and delivery limits
2021 / 10	10	China's challenge to US versus USSR	Economic/technology interdependence and power
2021 / 19	15	SCO aims and importance for India	Mandate → utility → internal contradictions
2021 / 20	15	AUKUS and existing Indo-Pacific partnerships	Purpose → complementarities → regional risks
2022 / 9	10	India's role during Sri Lanka's crisis	Immediate help → recovery → friendship
2022 / 10	10	BIMSTEC compared with SAARC	Common functions + different geography/membership
2022 / 19	15	I2U2 and India's global position	Complementary capabilities → practical projects
2022 / 20	15	India's climate policy across global fora	Continuity/change → equity → clean-energy diplomacy
2023 / 9	10	Conflicts within SCO and India's role	Identify fault lines → feasible mitigation
2023 / 10	10	Diaspora's rise in the West: benefits to India	Economic + political channels
2023 / 19	15	NATO/US-Europe strengthening: implications for India	Benefits and costs; independent judgement
2023 / 20	15	IMO: environment, safety and maritime security	Mandate → conventions → implementation gaps

Do not answer an old political situation as though it is current. Use the PYQ to learn its reasoning pattern, then update the example.

Yearly sources: [Q21], [Q22], [Q23].

PYQ map • 2024-2026

Paraphrased demands • use the original paper for exact wording

Year / Q	Marks	Question focus	What your answer must do
2024 / 9	10	The West and India as an alternative to China	Supply chains + strategic role, with examples
2024 / 10	10	India-Central Asia's evolving relations	Diplomatic/economic/strategic evaluation
2024 / 19	15	UNSC CTC and associated bodies	Functions → effectiveness → gaps
2024 / 20	15	Maldives: trade/energy, maritime security, stability	Geography → flows → rivalry → cooperation
2025 / 9	10	India-Africa digital partnership	Respect, co-development and durable institutions
2025 / 10	10	Globalisation and sovereign nationalism	Drivers → manifestations → qualified assessment
2025 / 19	15	Energy security and foreign-policy trajectories	West Asia + diversified future energy strategy
2025 / 20	15	East-West rivalry and stalled UN reform	Power conflict + structural/representation barriers
2026 / 9	10	IPMDA linking SAGAR and Quad strategy	Explain mechanism + critically assess the link
2026 / 10	10	BRICS as a Global South counterweight	Alternatives and influence; realistic limits
2026 / 19	15	Diaspora: heritage, networks and strategic influence	Economic/knowledge/cultural channels + limits
2026 / 20	15	BRI: Indian security and regional influence	Separate the two effects; add calibrated response

Do not answer an old political situation as though it is current. Use the PYQ to learn its reasoning pattern, then update the example.

Yearly sources: [Q24], [Q25], [Q26].

What to learn from topper copies

Observed on the same ForumIAS practice questions

Copies inspected: Ruhani (AIR 5, CSE 2023) and Kunal Rastogi (AIR 15, CSE 2023), ForumIAS MGP GS II practice booklets. The observations below concern visible writing choices; they do not prove why a candidate scored well in UPSC.

Answer inspected	What is visible	What you can adopt
West Asia, Q9 PDF pp. 19-20 in both copies	Ruhani: a benefits diagram and a separate risks section. Kunal: a location sketch followed by numbered arguments.	Match the two halves of the question: gains first, actors/risks next.
India-Africa, Q19 Ruhani pp. 47-49; Kunal pp. 47-49	Headings mirror inclusive, sustainable and equitable development. Visuals/examples support those headings.	Use the question's own criteria as body headings.
Indo-Pacific, Q20 PDF pp. 50-52 in both copies	Both use a map. Separate sections address ASEAN, rules, development and hurdles. Kunal gives denser examples.	A map should locate your argument; give each explicit demand space.

A useful caution from the same copies

• One older West Asia answer inaccurately links Saudi Arabia directly to the Abraham Accords. The UAE and Bahrain were the initial Arab signatories; do not reproduce the error.
• An old answer says ASEAN has ten members; Timor-Leste became the eleventh in October 2025. Historical copies need factual updating.
• A bold phrase, scholar's name or large diagram is useful only if it is accurate and answers the demand.

Your practical format

A direct 2-line introduction → headings taken from the question → short explanatory points with examples → one compact visual if useful → a qualified conclusion. Use ordinary English.

[T1], [T2] inspected practice copies; [ASEAN] membership update.

Framework 1 • Generate points quickly

Use six questions, then choose only the relevant ones



Thinking prompt	Example: Maldives
1. Where is it?	Near major Indian Ocean shipping routes; proximity to India's island territories matters.
2. What moves through the space?	Commercial shipping and energy flows; tourism and investment connect its economy externally.
3. What does India gain?	Maritime awareness, rescue cooperation, stable neighbourhood and trusted economic ties.
4. What can go wrong?	External military access, domestic political backlash, debt stress and climate vulnerability.
5. What constrains India?	The neighbour has sovereignty and alternatives; public opinion can limit security cooperation.
6. What can India deliver?	Predictable finance, visible development, coast-guard capacity, climate support and respectful diplomacy.

Turn one fact into an analytical point

Fact: Maldives is close to shipping routes.
Better point: Its location makes maritime monitoring and rescue cooperation valuable to India because disruption near these routes can affect trade and energy supplies.

Recall cue: Place → flows → interests → risks → constraints → response. Write these six words on rough space when you go blank.

Original teaching framework; Maldives context: [MAL].

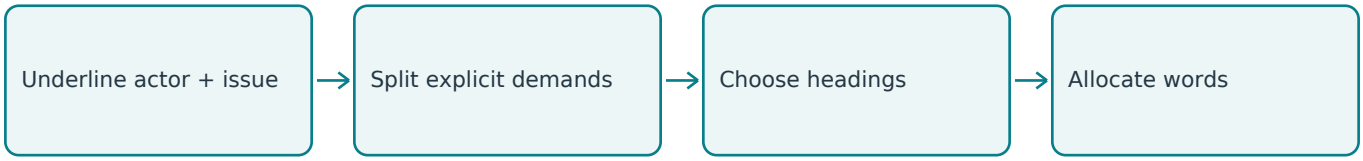
Framework 2 • Choose the right answer shape

A framework is a point generator, not a fixed answer template

Question type	Body structure	Common mistake
Bilateral relationship	Why it matters → cooperation → friction → realistic priorities.	Narrating diplomatic visits.
Effect of another country's policy	Policy change → transmission channels → Indian gains/costs → response.	Describing the foreign policy without its Indian effects.
Grouping / regionalism	Purpose → institutional tools → value for India → internal limits → reform.	Only listing members and summits.
International institution	Mandate → concrete tools → record → capacity/political gaps → reforms.	Generic criticism with no mandate.
Critically examine a claim	Evidence supporting the claim → conditions/counter-evidence → reasoned judgement.	Automatically accepting the question's premise.
Compare two arrangements	Compare on the same criteria: geography, membership, purpose, tools, limits.	Writing two disconnected mini essays.

Match the command word

Explain: make the mechanism clear. **Analyse:** show relationships and consequences. **Discuss:** cover relevant dimensions. **Evaluate:** use criteria and judge performance. **Critically examine:** test both strength and limitation. **Comment:** take a supported position.



Example: BRI in the 2026 paper

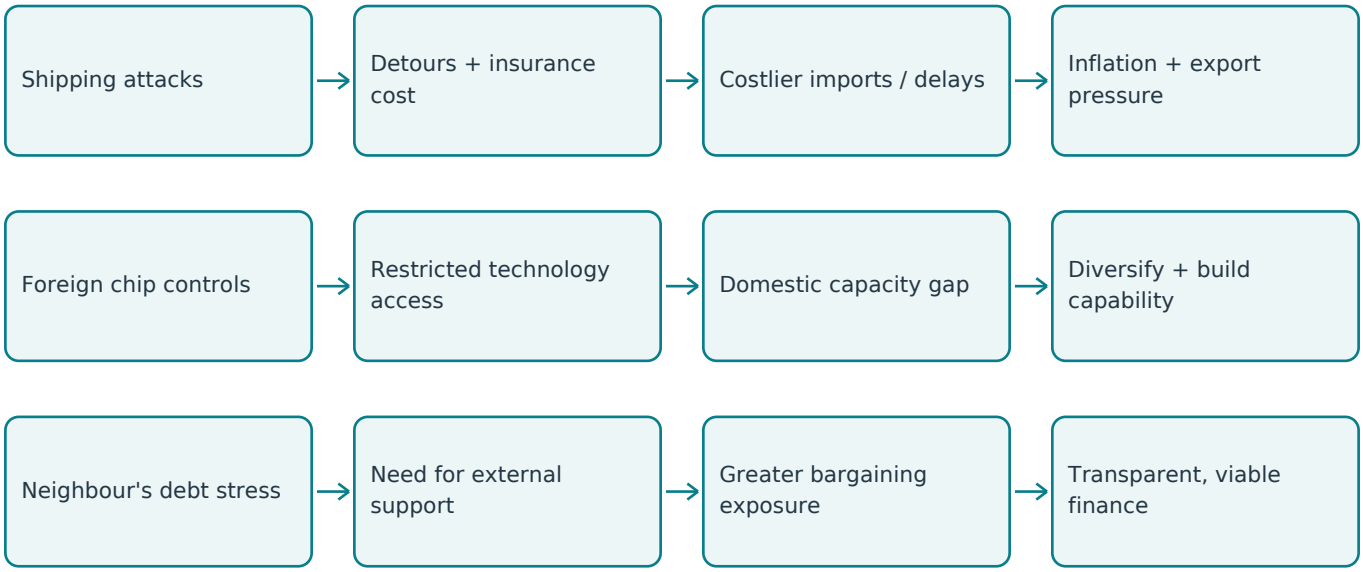
Demand 1: implications for **India's security**. Demand 2: implications for **regional influence**. Give both headings; then add a short response. A generic India-China essay misses the task.

[Q26]; framework and suggested word allocation are teaching advice.

Framework 3 • Write cause and effect

Make the missing middle visible

A point becomes analytical when it explains **how** a development produces an outcome. Avoid jumping directly from a headline to a sweeping conclusion.



The four-part point

Part	Example
Claim	India-Africa digital cooperation can strengthen long-term ties.
Mechanism	Training and institutional links make local agencies able to maintain and adapt systems.
Evidence	e-VidyaBharati/e-ArogyaBharati provides an identifiable education/health cooperation example.
Qualification	Poor connectivity, privacy risks and weak local capacity can reduce benefits.

Use precise language

Write "can increase dependence where debt, revenue and access terms are unfavourable" instead of "every loan is a debt trap". Write "diaspora networks can improve access" instead of "the diaspora controls foreign governments".

Trade-offs that generate balanced points

Market access versus domestic adjustment • security cooperation versus autonomy • connectivity versus sovereignty • speed versus accountability • climate ambition versus development finance • humanitarian engagement versus political legitimacy.

Original analytical chains; example: [AF-DIG].

Framework 4 • Finish an exam answer

A practical format for 150 and 250 words

Part	150-word answer	250-word answer
Opening	About 20 words: define the issue and state your direction.	About 30 words: context + qualified central argument.
Main demand(s)	About 100-110 words, usually 5-6 explained points.	About 180-190 words, usually 7-9 points under 2-3 headings.
Ending	About 20 words: a judgement or 1-2 priorities.	About 25-30 words: realistic response and overall judgement.
Visual	Only if it saves explanation; 3-4 labels may suffice.	One small map, comparison or causal diagram if directly useful.

Introductions you can adapt

• **Geography:** "Situated near important Indian Ocean routes, Maldives connects India's neighbourhood policy with maritime security."
• **Institution:** "The UN remains indispensable, but its effectiveness depends on both representative structures and cooperation among major powers."
• **Policy effect:** "Trade restrictions reshape India's market access as well as its opportunities to attract investment."
• **Debate:** "Strategic convergence has widened the partnership, while differences over autonomy and economic interests continue."

Conclusions with an action

Name **who should do what, through which instrument, to achieve what**. For example: "India should combine coast-guard training with trusted information sharing so island partners can enforce maritime law themselves."

Before you stop writing

Have I answered every demand? Explained the mechanism? Used relevant examples? Added one real limitation? Made a judgement? Kept within the word limit?

Suggested timings: around 7 minutes for a 10-marker and 10-11 minutes for a 15-marker, adjusted to your handwriting and full-paper practice. These are practice targets, not official rules.

Foreign policy • Essential concepts

A short background that helps current answers

Concept	Plain meaning	Use in an answer
National interest	Protecting security, prosperity, citizens and the ability to make choices.	Explain why a relationship matters.
Strategic autonomy	Capacity to choose issue-specific policies despite external pressure.	It requires economic/defence capacity and diversified dependencies.
Non-alignment / multi-alignment	Non-alignment arose in the Cold War; multiple present partnerships offer issue-based cooperation.	Neither means avoiding all positions or having no partners.
Balance of power	Preventing excessive concentration of power by building capabilities and partnerships.	Explain Indo-Pacific cooperation without calling every forum an alliance.
Soft power	Attraction through culture, credibility, values and institutions.	Can open doors; it does not remove hard security conflicts.
Global public goods	Benefits that cross borders, such as disease control or climate stability.	Explain why unilateral action is insufficient.

A minimum chronological spine

1947-1960s: sovereignty, decolonisation, non-alignment, development.
1962-1971: border war and regional security reshape priorities.
1991 onward: economic reform and diversified partnerships; Look East.
1998 onward: nuclear capability and gradual accommodation in global regimes.
2000s: deeper ties with major powers and regional economic integration.
2010s-2020s: maritime policy, technology, resilient supply chains and Global South platforms.

Three useful references, without name-dropping

Gujral Doctrine: non-reciprocity with specified smaller neighbours; no hostile use of territory; non-interference; respect for sovereignty; peaceful bilateral settlement. Joseph Nye: attraction and soft power. Article 51 of India's Constitution: international peace, international law and peaceful dispute settlement.

Article 51 is a Directive Principle. It should not be confused with Article 51 of the UN Charter, which concerns self-defence.

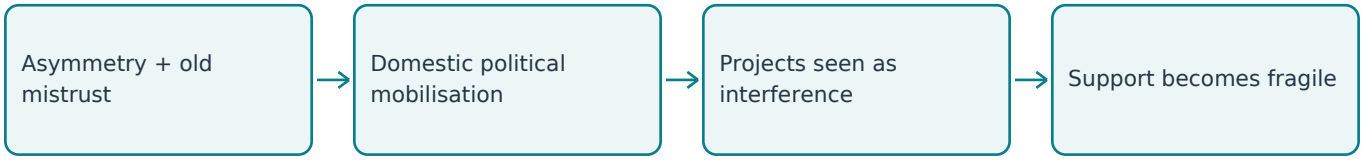
Historical synthesis; [CONST], [GUJ], [Q13].

Neighbourhood • The common framework

The region must be understood on its own terms



Why goodwill sometimes fails to produce influence



• **Geographic closeness creates exposure:** violence, floods, migration and disease cross borders.
• **Economic asymmetry creates anxiety:** a small neighbour may diversify partners even while valuing India.
• **Domestic politics matters:** parties, border communities, businesses and provincial governments have different interests.
• **China matters, but does not explain everything:** neighbours also seek infrastructure, credit, markets and bargaining space.
• **Delivery decides credibility:** delayed procurement, customs friction or poorly communicated projects can erode trust.

Reusable way forward

Consult early → select locally useful projects → publish clear costs and timelines → involve border states/communities → monitor delivery → maintain ties across political changes.

Analytical judgement: India's size is an advantage when it provides regional public goods; it becomes a source of mistrust when local agency is ignored.

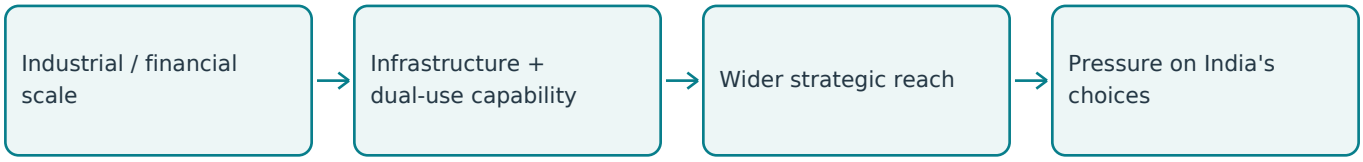
Recall: Why would a neighbour accept help from a rival power even if it has cultural ties with India? Generate three non-China explanations before reading country notes.

[Q13], [Q22], [Q24], [Q26]; country examples on following pages.

China • Compete, manage, protect

PYQ links: 2013, 2014, 2017, 2021, 2024, 2026

Dimension	Content you can use
Boundary and military risk	An unsettled boundary, differing perceptions of the LAC and military deployments create mistrust. Separate disengagement, de-escalation and final boundary settlement.
Economic link	Intermediate goods and manufacturing inputs can support Indian production; concentrated dependence raises disruption and bargaining risks.
Regional influence	Infrastructure, finance and political ties expand China's presence. Analyse project terms and actual access rather than treating every port as a military base.
Wider order	Both cooperate in some multilateral forums while differing on regional security and institutional influence.



India's response: four connected tracks

• **Deter:** maintain credible border and maritime capability with reliable logistics.
• **De-risk:** identify critical input dependence; diversify suppliers and expand competitive domestic production.
• **Engage:** sustain military/diplomatic communication and practical confidence-building measures.
• **Partner:** offer credible regional projects and work with other powers without surrendering independent choices.

Dated example and correct inference

The October 2024 patrolling arrangement concerned Depsang and Demchok. It illustrates crisis management. It does not, by itself, establish that the boundary dispute has been settled.

Exam line: "A stable relationship needs credible deterrence, reduced vulnerabilities and sustained communication; economic engagement alone cannot resolve security mistrust."

Map cue: Show India, the Himalayan frontier as a broad zone, Indian Ocean routes and a few relevant ports. Avoid attempting disputed boundary detail in a tiny sketch.

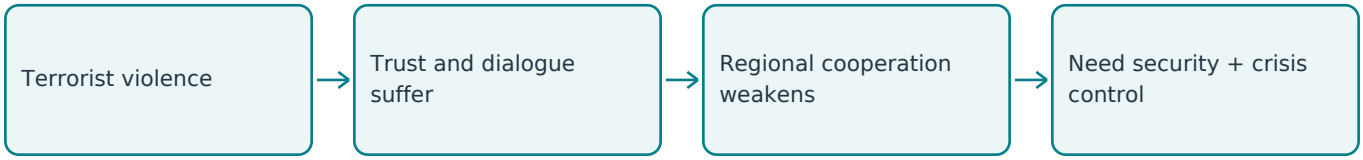
[CHINA]; [Q17], [Q24], [Q26]. Analysis and recommendations are teaching synthesis.

Pakistan and Afghanistan

Security choices must distinguish states, institutions and people

Country	Core stakes	Constraints / appropriate response
Pakistan	Cross-border terrorism; escalation control; water; regional transit; people-to-people links.	Hostile security policies and mistrust limit cooperation. Combine deterrence and credible counter-terror demands with crisis communication and humanitarian channels.
Afghanistan	Terror safe havens; regional stability; humanitarian welfare; access toward Central Asia; past development investment.	Security, rights and uncertain political arrangements complicate engagement. Protect assistance, assess security commitments and maintain practical contacts.

Pakistan: structure a difficult relationship



Soft power has a limited role: sport, pilgrims, culture and medical links can reduce social hostility, but cannot substitute for action against organised violence. This is the qualification needed for the 2015 question.

Water diplomacy needs an updated note

The Indus Waters Treaty is a 1960 framework. India announced that it would hold it in abeyance in April 2025; an official Indian statement dated 31 August 2026 reiterated that position. Attribute this as India's stated position. Legal interpretation is contested; "abeyance" is not the same as a mutually agreed treaty termination.

Afghanistan: separate engagement from recognition

India restored its Kabul technical mission to embassy status in October 2025. Use this as evidence of deeper practical engagement; do not automatically equate a mission upgrade with formal recognition of a government.

Balanced point: Humanitarian aid should reach people while security concerns and the rights of women and minorities remain part of diplomatic engagement.

Recall: Explain how a security vacuum in Afghanistan can affect India without a shared, directly usable transit route.

[IWT] official Indian position; [AFG] embassy update; [Q13], [Q15].

Bangladesh and Myanmar

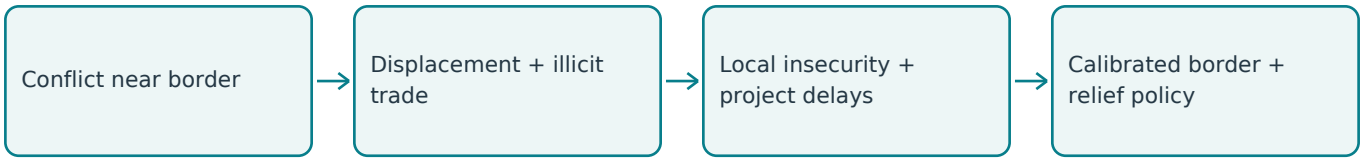
Border management, local welfare and eastern connectivity

Country	Why it matters	Friction and practical priorities
Bangladesh	Access to India's Northeast; river systems; power/trade links; Bay of Bengal; shared historical and social connections.	Domestic political shifts, border incidents, water-sharing and identity politics can weaken trust. Protect functional cooperation and avoid identifying the relationship with one party.
Myanmar	Land bridge toward Southeast Asia; border communities; insurgency/drug networks; Bay of Bengal access.	Conflict can disrupt projects, displace people and increase illicit flows. Secure access, deliver humanitarian help and coordinate policy with border states.

Bangladesh: three points that travel across questions

• **Connectivity:** transit and ports can reduce isolation of the Northeast, provided customs and logistics function.
• **Federal dimension:** rivers and border concerns require coordination with Indian states and local communities.
• **Trust:** the 2015 Land Boundary Agreement shows that negotiated settlement can convert a contentious legacy into cooperation.

Myanmar: show the policy tension



Examples: Kaladan Multimodal Transit Transport Project; India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway; Operation Brahma after the March 2025 earthquake. Distinguish completed components from an end-to-end functioning corridor.

A useful concluding line

"Eastern connectivity will be durable when it improves the security and livelihoods of border communities, rather than remaining an infrastructure promise."

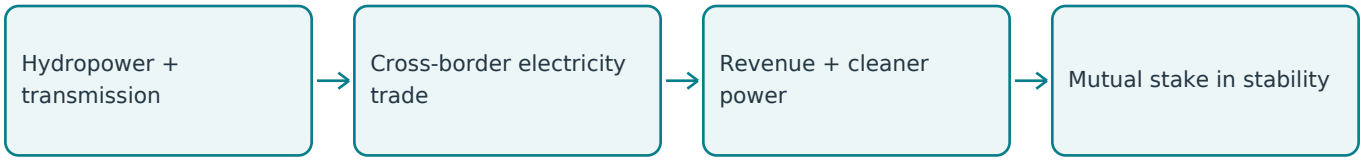
Map cue: Northeast India → Bangladesh / Myanmar → Bay of Bengal / Thailand. Label the connection and its purpose, not every state boundary.

[BAN], [BRAHMA]; corridor descriptions: [MEA].

Nepal and Bhutan

Water-energy cooperation with sovereignty and local benefits

Country	Core interests	Risks / response
Nepal	Open-border social ties; trade/transit; Himalayan ecology; hydropower; flood management.	Boundary disputes, uneven benefits and political mistrust. Use regular dialogue, reliable transit, transparent power agreements and local benefit-sharing.
Bhutan	Trusted development partnership; hydropower; Himalayan security; ecological links.	Debt/revenue concentration, project delays and sensitive regional security. Diversify cooperation and respect Bhutan's sovereign decisions.



Points that make this an analytical answer

• **Interdependence:** Nepal/Bhutan can earn revenue while India gains flexible clean electricity; the benefit depends on transmission and predictable purchasing arrangements.
• **Beyond energy:** storage, floods, sediment, ecology and downstream livelihoods make river cooperation wider than electricity sales.
• **Asymmetry:** a project may be economically useful but politically unpopular if local costs are ignored.
• **Regional scale:** electricity trade can connect South Asian markets if grids and regulatory approvals align.

Two factual anchors

India and Nepal signed a long-term power-trade agreement in January 2024 with a 10,000 MW export ambition over ten years; treat the number as a target. The India-Bhutan friendship treaty was revised in 2007, reflecting a modern sovereign partnership.

Way forward: predictable tariffs; timely projects; ecological assessment; community compensation; joint flood forecasting; wider trade and skills links.

Recall: Why can a profitable hydropower project still become a diplomatic problem? Answer through distribution, ecology and sovereignty.

[NEPAL], [BHUTAN], [POWER24].

Sri Lanka and Maldives

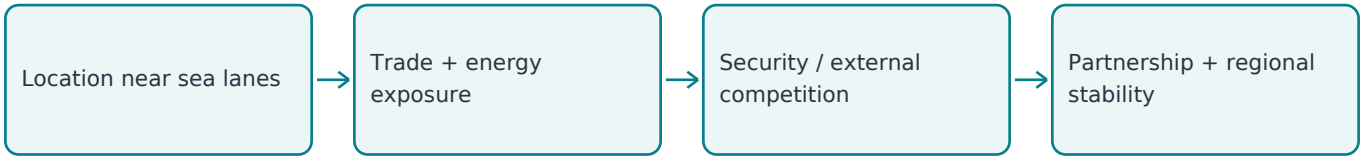
Maritime relevance + domestic politics + credible delivery

Country	Usable content	What a balanced answer adds
Sri Lanka	Shipping location; trade and investment; Tamil connections; fisheries; Chinese economic presence; crisis assistance.	Debt problems have multiple causes. Support recovery and local welfare; discuss fisheries and minority concerns through dialogue.
Maldives	Location near Indian Ocean routes; maritime awareness; coast guard/rescue; tourism; infrastructure; climate and debt vulnerability.	Domestic politics and sovereignty shape cooperation. Development credibility and public trust are as important as security arrangements.

Sri Lanka: the 2022 crisis as an example

India provided assistance close to USD 4 billion in 2022. Use the dated amount to show crisis response through finance and essential supplies. Then explain the next stage: recovery, debt sustainability, investment and people-centred projects.

Maldives: answer all layers of the 2024 PYQ



- **Trade/energy:** maritime disruption can affect Indian imports and exports.
- **Security:** information sharing and coast-guard capability improve monitoring and rescue.
- **Regional stability:** financial resilience and climate adaptation reduce recurring crisis pressure.
- **Competition:** external access arrangements matter; identify evidence before claiming a foreign military base.

Dated partnership example

The October 2024 India-Maldives vision document links economic cooperation with maritime security. It helps show why these should be analysed together.

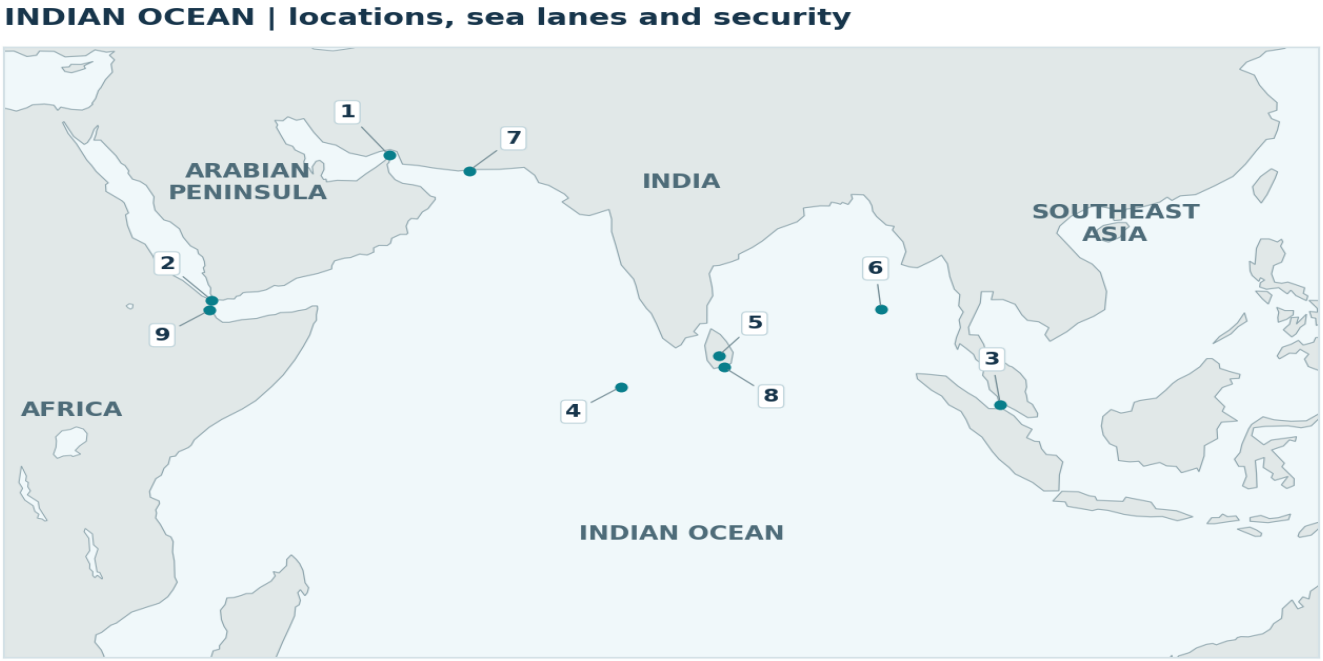
Exam line: "Durable maritime influence grows from a partner's security and development choices being served together."

Recall: Give two reasons a small island state has strategic importance beyond its land area.

[LANKA], [MAL]; [Q22], [Q24].

Indian Ocean • Turn location into an argument

A coast-only location map; international boundaries are not shown



Map label	Why you may use it in IR
1 Hormuz; 2 Bab el-Mandeb; 3 Malacca	Chokepoints → disruption → freight/energy exposure → route protection and diversification.
4 Maldives; 5 Sri Lanka; 6 Andaman & Nicobar	Island geography → monitoring, rescue and communication → maritime partnerships.
7 Gwadar; 8 Hambantota; 9 Djibouti	Assess commercial terms, possible dual use and actual access separately. Djibouti hosts a Chinese military support base; do not extend that claim automatically to all ports.

India's toolkit

Awareness: IFC-IOR and trusted information sharing. **Capacity:** coast-guard training, patrol capability and hydrography. **Public goods:** disaster relief, search and rescue and environmental protection. **Diplomacy:** IORA, island partnerships and coordinated regional projects.

A diagram you can draw in 30 seconds

India at centre; Hormuz to the northwest, Bab el-Mandeb to the west, Malacca to the east; a sea-lane arrow below India. Add Maldives and Sri Lanka only if the question needs them.

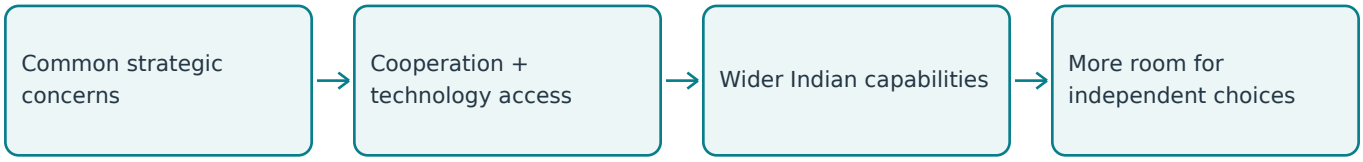
SAGAR (2015): Security and Growth for All in the Region. MAHASAGAR (2025): Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions. Retain SAGAR when a PYQ explicitly asks about it.

[QUAD], [MAHA], [IOR-COM]; basemap: [MAP].

United States • Convergence with friction

PYQ links: 2019, 2020, 2021, 2024

Area	Why interests converge	Where friction arises
Security	Maritime stability; defence technology; exercises; a favourable Indo-Pacific balance.	India protects autonomy and has other defence partnerships.
Technology	Semiconductors, AI, space, research and secure supply chains.	Export controls, intellectual property and unequal industrial capacity.
Economy	Markets, services, investment, energy and manufacturing diversification.	Tariffs, domestic regulation, subsidies and migration policies.
People	Students, professionals, research and business networks.	Visa uncertainty, worker welfare and political controversy.



How to write the qualification

• Convergence does not make India a treaty ally or make interests identical.
• Technology access is valuable when domestic firms absorb capability; purchases alone can create dependence.
• Supply-chain relocation depends on infrastructure, skills and stable regulation, not geopolitics alone.
• A stronger US-Europe partnership may provide technology and investment, while escalation or sanctions can complicate India's choices.

Dated anchors

The February 2025 joint statement launched COMPACT and TRUST. A February 2026 statement announced a framework for an interim trade agreement. Distinguish a framework, signed agreement and entry into force; do not recycle a tariff rate without checking its product coverage and effective date.

Way forward: focus on co-development, export-market reliability, research links and transparent resolution of trade disputes.

Recall: Name one domain where cooperation widens autonomy and one where it could create a new dependence.

[US25], [US26]; [Q19], [Q20], [Q24].

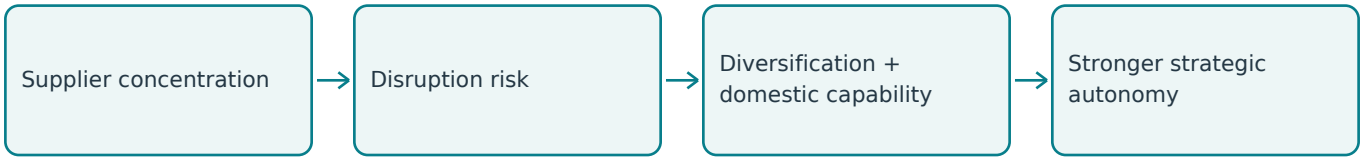
Russia • Continuity amid a changing order

Strategic autonomy is strengthened by reducing vulnerabilities

A compact relationship note

• **Established value:** defence cooperation, civil nuclear energy, energy trade and diplomatic familiarity.
• **Present pressure:** the Ukraine war and sanctions complicate payments, logistics, technology access and relations with Western partners.
• **Structural risk:** excessive concentration in any supplier exposes India to disruption and weakens bargaining.
• **Wider setting:** Russia-China convergence changes India's regional calculations; India should assess it without treating Russia as simply controlled by China.

Do not use this shortcut	Use this reasoning
"Buy from one partner to prove friendship."	Assess operational need, lifecycle cost, supply reliability and technology transfer.
"Autonomy means equal distance from all."	Choose according to the issue, national interest and wider consequences.
"Economic pragmatism removes normative concerns."	Protect essential interests while supporting sovereignty, civilian protection and peaceful settlement.



A comparison for the 2020 defence PYQ

US ties can add advanced systems, interoperability and Indo-Pacific cooperation; Russian ties support established equipment and nuclear/defence links. Compare on technology, reliability, dependency and geopolitical costs. A simple winner-versus-loser answer is weak.

Dated anchor: The December 2025 annual summit reaffirmed cooperation across defence and economic fields. A joint statement records commitments; assess delivery separately.
Exam line: "Diversification should reduce vulnerability without abruptly weakening operational readiness."

[RUS25]; [Q20], [Q23].

Europe, Japan and Australia

Complementary partners; avoid writing one generic "West"

Partner	Three useful areas	Qualification / India's priority
EU	Market access; clean technology; standards and regulatory influence.	CBAM and compliance costs affect exporters. Negotiations on the FTA concluded in January 2026; this alone does not mean it is in force.
France	Defence co-development; space/civil nuclear cooperation; Indian Ocean cooperation.	Translate strategic trust into technology and industrial capability. Partnership was elevated in February 2026.
Germany / UK	Advanced industry/skills and investment; services/research/people links respectively.	Distinguish national partnerships from EU institutions. Check any agreement's current legal status before citing.
Japan	Quality infrastructure; industrial investment/skills; maritime and supply-chain cooperation.	Slow execution, market-access barriers and business adjustment can limit economic potential.
Australia	Critical minerals; education; maritime cooperation and trade.	Value requires processing capacity, resilient supply contracts and worker/student safeguards.

Japan: why the question returned in 2019

India offers scale, markets and a wider regional role; Japan offers capital, technology and quality infrastructure. Together they can support connectivity and a more balanced Indo-Pacific. Their economic potential still requires better logistics, skills, standards compliance and faster project delivery.

Two current anchors

EU-India negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, subject to further legal steps. The India-Japan August 2025 vision sets a next-decade direction: use it to illustrate cooperation, not as proof that investment targets have already been achieved.

Comparison method: Compare partners on the same headings: capital, technology, markets, security and people. This also helps answer supply-chain questions.

Recall: How can an environmental regulation become a foreign-policy issue? Explain the EU example through trade costs and technology.

[EU26], [EU-TEXT], [FR26], [JPN25], [CBAM].

Act East, ASEAN and the Indo-Pacific

Trade, the Northeast, rules and public goods



Dimension	A point with a mechanism
Economic	Better ports, roads and customs can connect the Northeast to Southeast Asian production networks; infrastructure alone is insufficient.
Strategic	ASEAN-led forums let India engage multiple partners and support a regional order in which smaller states retain choices.
Maritime	Navigation and lawful resource use matter to trade. Partnerships should also offer rescue, health and climate benefits.
Social	Buddhist/cultural links, education and diaspora ties deepen familiarity but need contemporary economic substance.

Constraints and response

Constraints: instability in Myanmar; project delays; trade imbalance and rules-of-origin concerns; differing ASEAN members' interests; great-power rivalry. **Response:** prioritise viable links, border logistics, services/skills, maritime capacity and ASEAN consultation.

Use the right present fact

ASEAN has 11 members after Timor-Leste's admission on 26 October 2025. "ASEAN centrality" means a central role for ASEAN-led regional architecture; it does not mean all members share identical security choices.

Exam line: "Act East becomes credible when physical connectivity is matched by market integration and local economic opportunity."

[ASEAN], [Q16], [QUAD]; coast-only basemap [MAP].

West Asia • A portfolio of interests

PYQ links: 2017 energy; 2018 Iran; 2022 I2U2; 2025 energy



Partner / space	What to remember
Gulf states	Energy, investment, labour welfare, food cooperation and logistics. Build long-term clean-energy and industrial ties alongside hydrocarbons.
Israel	Defence, agricultural/water technology and innovation. Cooperation does not require abandoning support for Palestinian rights or a negotiated settlement.
Iran	Geography, Chabahar and access toward Afghanistan/Central Asia. Sanctions and regional tensions complicate implementation.
Red Sea / Gulf sea lanes	Conflict can raise freight, insurance and energy uncertainty; monitor transmission into India rather than simply recounting battles.

How to generate a balanced response

Diversify sources/routes; build reserves and efficiency; protect workers and prepare evacuations; maintain diplomatic channels; support civilian protection and peaceful settlement; pursue viable projects with financial and sanctions due diligence.

Two distinctions that save marks

I2U2 is a project-focused grouping of India, Israel, UAE and US; it is not a collective-defence alliance. IMEC is a planned connectivity framework; announced routes and components should not be described as an already functioning integrated corridor.

Recall: Why does India need separate relationships with actors that disagree strongly with each other? Answer using the four interests above.

[I2U2], [IMEC], [CHAB]; [Q17], [Q18], [Q22], [Q25].

Central Asia • Access is the central constraint

Energy and Eurasian geography need a viable route



Interest	Mechanism / example
Security	Afghanistan-linked instability and extremist networks create shared concerns; SCO offers a forum, with limits.
Resources	Energy and minerals offer diversification, but transport and commercial viability determine access.
Connectivity	Chabahar, INSTC and the Ashgabat Agreement provide different, partly overlapping routes/frameworks; they are not interchangeable.
Development	Skills, digital services, health, pharmaceuticals and business links can work alongside large corridors.

Five countries to locate

Kazakhstan • Kyrgyzstan • Tajikistan • Turkmenistan • Uzbekistan. Think of them as distinct sovereign actors, not a single resource block.

The 2024 PYQ structure

Diplomatic ties and platforms → economic opportunities and access limits → strategic setting involving Afghanistan and external powers → realistic priorities. The June 2025 India-Central Asia Dialogue provides a dated follow-up example.

India's May 2024 contract concerns equipping and operating the Shahid Beheshti terminal at Chabahar for ten years. It is not a transfer of sovereignty over the port.

Map caution: Routes shown are schematic relationships, not surveyed alignments or claims of complete operational readiness.

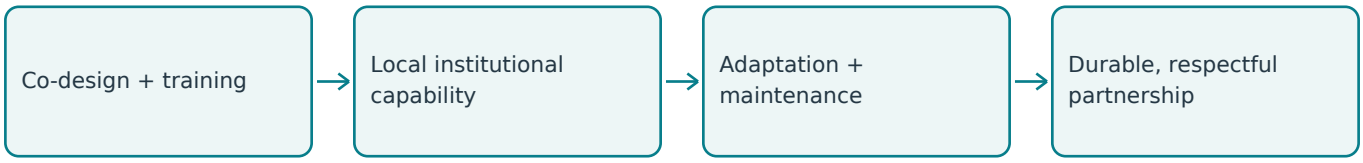
[CA25], [CHAB]; [Q18], [Q24]; basemap [MAP].

Africa, Latin America and Pacific islands

Partner on development priorities, with local ownership

Region	Content for a mains answer	Needed qualification
Africa	Education/health; ITEC training; digital systems; energy and minerals; trade; maritime links; representation in global forums.	Africa is diverse. Co-design, local jobs, maintenance and debt sustainability determine credibility.
Latin America	Lithium/copper and other resources; food/energy links; medicines; market diversification; Brazil and wider South-South cooperation.	Distance, language, logistics, processing concentration and ecological/local consent issues matter.
Pacific islands	Climate adaptation; resilient infrastructure; health, training and development partnership through FIPIC.	Small land area does not mean small maritime stakes. Avoid reducing partners to sites of great-power rivalry.

Africa digital partnership: the 2025 demand



• **Mutual respect:** choose priorities with the partner; protect data and local decision-making.
• **Co-development:** train staff, adapt systems and enable domestic firms instead of supplying a closed product.
• **Institutions:** connect universities, health agencies and regulators for long-term learning.
• **Example:** e-VidyaBharati/e-ArogyaBharati illustrates education and health links. It does not by itself prove every project is equally effective.

Critical angle

If systems are costly to maintain or concentrate data/control outside the partner country, digital cooperation can reproduce dependence. Judge partnership quality by usable local capability.

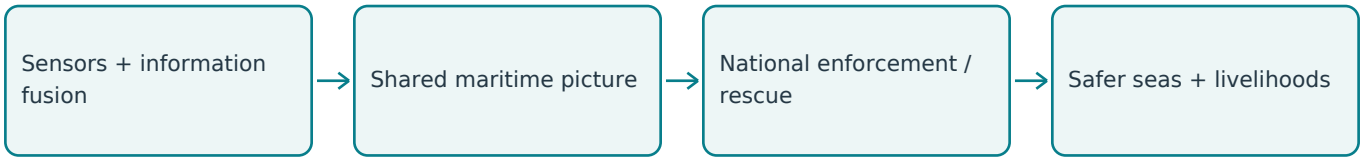
Recall: Give three differences between an extractive resource relationship and a development partnership.

[AF-DIG], [G20], [FIPIC]; [Q15], [Q21], [Q25].

Quad, AUKUS, IPMDA and IORA

Compare purpose before comparing strength

Arrangement	Purpose / instrument	India's position and limits
Quad	India, US, Japan, Australia; consultation and practical Indo-Pacific cooperation, including maritime awareness and public goods.	India is a member. Quad is neither a formal military alliance nor a trade bloc.
AUKUS	Australia, UK, US; security/defence-technology partnership including conventionally armed nuclear-powered submarines.	India is not a member. Distinct mandate; cannot simply replace Quad's wider role.
IPMDA	Quad initiative launched in 2022 to improve near-real-time maritime information for regional partners.	Information helps detect suspicious activity; action still requires local law, vessels, training and trust.
IORA	Indian Ocean Rim Association; regional cooperation across the Indian Ocean.	Useful inclusive forum; diverse interests and limited enforcement constrain delivery.



Critical assessment of IPMDA

• **Bridges visions:** Quad resources can support India's cooperative maritime goals by helping partners see activity in their waters.
• **Benefits:** detection of illegal fishing, trafficking or suspicious movements; better coordination.
• **Limits:** data quality, confidentiality, uneven enforcement capacity and concern about strategic alignment.
• **Response:** consent-based sharing, safeguards, training and useful coast-guard capacity.

A memorable distinction

SAGAR/MAHASAGAR: Indian visions. Quad: a four-country grouping. IPMDA: a practical initiative. IORA: a wider regional association. Do not treat them as synonyms.

[QUAD], [AUKUS], [IORA], [MAHA].

BRICS, SCO and G20

More voice is useful; cohesion decides results

Forum	Value to India	Limits to evaluate
BRICS	South-South coordination; development finance through NDB; arguments for representation in global institutions; diversified partnerships.	Members differ on security, trade and governance. Expansion widens reach but can complicate consensus.
SCO	Eurasian dialogue; regional security and counter-terror cooperation; engagement with Central Asia.	India-China/Pakistan tensions and competing priorities restrict common action. Membership does not settle bilateral disputes.
G20	Coordination among major economies on growth, finance, development, digital and climate issues.	It is an informal forum; implementation depends on members and other institutions. Major-power rivalry complicates consensus.

How BRICS can act as an alternative

• **Voice:** coordinate demands for a more representative international order.
• **Finance:** widen development-finance options; NDB is a concrete institutional example.
• **Agenda:** bring debt, technology access and development needs into negotiations.
• **Qualification:** additional forums complement existing institutions; they do not automatically replace them or produce a common currency.

Use current, limited anchors

Indonesia became a full BRICS member in January 2025. The African Union joined G20 in September 2023. These examples show broadened participation. Do not equate a partner-country category with full membership.

SCO question: start with its aims, then show what internal conflicts prevent it from doing; suggest functional cooperation without implying India can remove all rivalries.

Recall: Why might a larger grouping be more representative but less effective? Explain through bargaining and implementation.

[BRICS], [BR-ID], [SCO], [G20]; [Q21], [Q23], [Q26].

SAARC, BIMSTEC and smaller coalitions

Compare on common criteria; treat forums as complementary

Criterion	SAARC	BIMSTEC
Geography / membership	South Asia; includes Pakistan and Afghanistan.	Bay of Bengal bridge: Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Myanmar, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Thailand.
Main opportunity	Broad South Asian cooperation and social/economic links.	Links Neighbourhood First with Act East; connectivity, energy, security and development.
Main constraint	Bilateral security tensions and weak political trust.	Project delays, Myanmar instability, capacity gaps and unfinished integration.
India's approach	Preserve useful technical/people links where possible.	Prioritise deliverable projects and regulatory coordination.

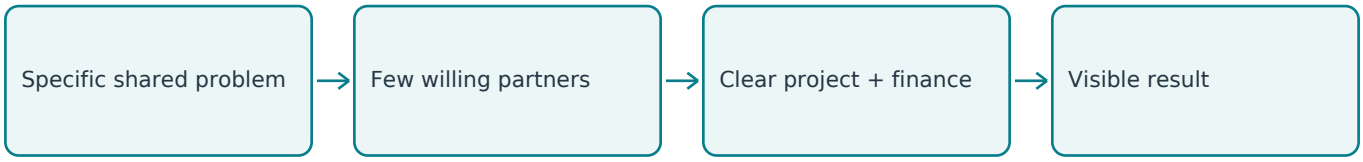
Why BIMSTEC is not merely a renamed SAARC

It has a different geographic centre and membership. It avoids one set of political constraints but has its own. The better judgement is that India needs overlapping forums matched to tasks, rather than assuming one forum fully replaces another.

Dated example

The April 2025 BIMSTEC summit adopted Bangkok Vision 2030 and saw the signing of an Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation. Use these as instruments for potential integration; assess implementation separately.

Minilateral cooperation: when a smaller group helps



Examples: I2U2 for complementary project capabilities; BBIN for subregional links. **Limits:** inclusion, host-country consent, institutional capacity and follow-through. A smaller group is faster only when interests and delivery capacity align.

Recall: Give two reasons BIMSTEC could progress despite SAARC's difficulties, and two reasons it might still struggle.

[BIM25], [SAARC], [I2U2]; [Q16], [Q22].

United Nations • Mandate, power and reform

The 2025 PYQ requires more than a list of veto problems

Body / mechanism	Core role	One useful distinction
General Assembly	Broad representation, discussion and recommendations.	A broad consensus can create legitimacy; most recommendations do not enforce themselves.
Security Council	Primary responsibility for international peace and security; sanctions and other Charter tools.	15 members: 5 permanent and 10 elected. Veto politics constrains many substantive decisions.
ECOSOC	Coordinates economic/social work and links commissions, agencies and development discussions.	Examples: Commission on the Status of Women and Statistical Commission. Agencies are not all ECOSOC commissions.
ICJ / ICC	ICJ: UN principal judicial organ, state disputes and advisory opinions. ICC: individual criminal responsibility under a separate treaty.	They differ in mandate, membership/jurisdiction and institutional position.

Why reform remains difficult

• **Power:** existing permanent members resist losing influence and disagree over conflicts.
• **Representation:** Africa and other underrepresented regions seek meaningful voice.
• **Rival candidates:** disagreement over new seats and categories blocks a coalition.
• **Legal threshold:** Charter amendment needs adoption by two-thirds of the General Assembly and ratification by two-thirds of UN members, including all permanent members.

India's reform argument

Link population, economic role, peacekeeping and Global South representation to institutional legitimacy. Work with G4 and African partners, while recognising disagreement on seats, veto and reform sequencing.

Balanced judgement: East-West confrontation worsens paralysis, but it is not the sole explanation. Regional rivalries and the Charter's amendment design also matter.

Way forward: pursue representative expansion alongside transparency, better working methods and improved coordination with regional bodies.

[UN108], [UN-VOTE], [UN-REF], [ECOSOC]; [Q17], [Q25].

WTO, IMF, World Bank, NDB and AIIB

Know which institution solves which problem

Institution	Mandate / instrument	India's interest and critical issue
WTO	Trade agreements, negotiations, monitoring and dispute settlement.	Predictable access plus space for food security/development; address distorted subsidies and impaired appeals.
IMF	Macroeconomic surveillance, balance-of-payments finance and capacity development.	Crisis stability, fair quotas/voice and adjustment that protects vulnerable people.
World Bank	Long-term development finance, knowledge and poverty reduction.	Infrastructure/human development; safeguards, debt sustainability and adequate concessional finance.
NDB	Development bank created by BRICS countries; infrastructure and sustainable development.	Additional finance and greater borrower options; judge project quality and governance.
AIIB	Multilateral development bank focused on infrastructure and connectivity.	Project finance and standards; India's participation is compatible with disagreement with China elsewhere.

WTO answer: retain four themes

Agriculture: food security, public stockholding and subsidy asymmetry. **Development:** meaningful special and differential treatment. **Disputes:** accessible, credible settlement. **New issues:** digital trade, climate measures and industrial subsidies without excluding developing-country needs.

Current anchor, carefully stated

WTO MC14 in March 2026 adopted selected decisions but left major issues for further work. This illustrates selective agreement amid unresolved reform; it is not evidence that dispute-settlement problems have all been solved.

Tied aid: donor-linked procurement may offer finance and technical quality; it can also reduce competition, inflate costs and restrict policy choice. Compare lifecycle cost and local capacity instead of accepting or rejecting all conditions.

Recall: Why does a temporary external-payments crisis need a different institution from a long-term drinking-water project?

[WTO-FOOD], [WTO26], [IMF-WB], [NDB], [AIIB]; [Q13-Q18].

WHO, UNESCO, IMO and counter-terror bodies

Evaluate institutions against their actual tools

Body	Mandate / concrete tool	Evaluation point
WHO	Health guidance, international coordination and the International Health Regulations.	Its effectiveness depends on timely state reporting, funding, trust and national health capacity; it is not a world health police force.
UNESCO	Education, science, culture and communication; heritage conventions and cooperation.	Funding and political disputes affect work. Evaluate educational/cultural outcomes, not only controversies.
IMO	International shipping standards: SOLAS (safety), MARPOL (pollution), STCW (seafarer training).	Rules need implementation by flag/port/coastal states; IMO does not itself patrol every sea lane.
CTC / CTED	CTC monitors counter-terror obligations; CTED assesses gaps and facilitates assistance.	Technical work helps capacity; selective cooperation, politics and uneven enforcement limit results.
FATF	International standards and mutual evaluation on money laundering and terrorist financing.	Improves financial scrutiny; it is neither a UN court nor an agency that directly prosecutes terrorists.

Three distinctions UPSC can test

• **CTC versus sanctions committees:** CTC/CTED implementation assessment is distinct from the 1267/1989/2253 ISIL-Al-Qaida sanctions regime and its monitoring support.
• **Adoption versus operation:** WHO's Pandemic Agreement was adopted in May 2025; the PABS annex was still under negotiation in July 2026. Do not call the entire regime fully operational.
• **Historical UNESCO question:** the MacBride report (1980) concerned unequal communication flows and a fairer information order. Link India's developmental concern to wider access and capacity, while recognising debates over media freedom.

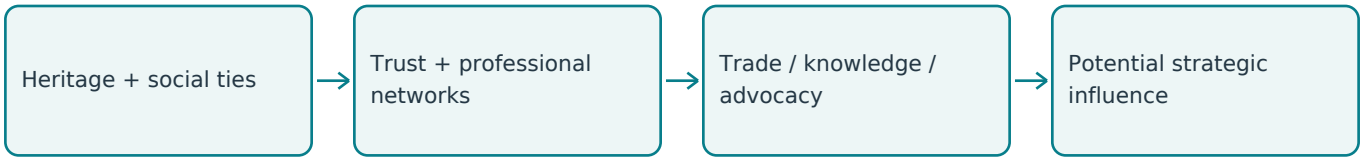
Institution answer formula

The body has the mandate to ___. Its instrument ___ helps by ___. Its effectiveness is limited by ___. India should support ___ because it addresses that specific gap.

[WHO25], [WHO26], [MAC], [IMO], [CTC], [FATF].

Diaspora • Convert networks into influence

PYQ links: 2017, 2020, 2023, 2026



Channel	Mechanism	Example type
Economic	Remittances support households and external receipts; networks connect firms, markets and investors.	Gulf labour networks; professionals and entrepreneurs in advanced economies.
Knowledge	Research links, mentoring, skills and venture capital connect Indian institutions to global ecosystems.	University collaboration; technology/startup networks.
Cultural	Language, cinema, food and community institutions can build familiarity and attraction.	Long-established communities in Southeast Asia and newer professional migration.
Political	Civic participation and advocacy can improve access and visibility for shared concerns.	Elected representatives and community organisations, subject to host-country democratic processes.

Why the influence is not automatic

• The diaspora is diverse in class, generation, religion, citizenship and priorities.
• Citizens of another state have obligations to that state; shared ancestry does not determine political decisions.
• Visa restrictions, discrimination, unsafe work and crisis exposure can turn an apparent asset into a protection challenge.
• Brain drain, skill shortages at home and unequal migration access need domestic policy responses.

One dated data point is enough

World Bank's August 2026 WDI discussion puts India's 2024 remittance inflows at about USD 138 billion. Earlier estimates were lower. Always label the calendar year and source; do not mix this with a fiscal-year RBI series.

Policy priorities: safe migration and consular help; lower transfer costs; fair recruitment; research and investment channels; diaspora engagement that respects host-country sovereignty.

Recall: Explain one pathway from culture to economic influence, then explain why that pathway might fail.

[REMIT]; [Q17], [Q20], [Q23], [Q26].

Connectivity • A corridor is more than a line

Finance + infrastructure + rules + stability = usable access



Framework	What connects to what	What to assess
INSTC	India-Iran-Eurasia/Russia through a multimodal network with several possible branches.	Missing links, customs, sanctions/payments and cargo economics.
Chabahar	An Iranian port providing an access option toward Afghanistan and Central Asia.	Terminal operations, inland links, finance and political risks.
IMEC	Proposed India-Gulf-Europe ship/rail and associated connectivity.	Regional stability, missing rail sections, customs and financing. It is a planned framework.
BRI / CPEC	Chinese infrastructure/connectivity initiative; CPEC crosses territory claimed by India.	Sovereignty, contract terms, actual access, debt/revenue viability and local agency.

A powerful cause-effect chain

Better infrastructure reduces distance only when border procedures, standards, payments and security permit goods to move. Otherwise a corridor exists on a map but does not create reliable trade.

Good evaluation criteria: sovereign consent; debt sustainability; transparent contracts; local jobs; environmental/social safeguards; interoperability; and realistic maintenance finance.

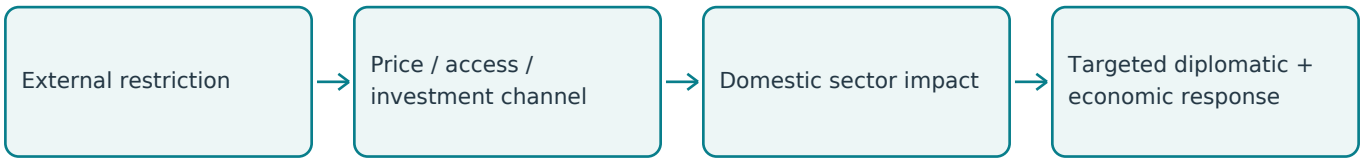
Map is schematic: lines indicate relationships and broad direction, not precise routes or a claim that every segment is operational. No international boundaries are drawn.

[IMEC], [CHAB], [CA25], [Q26]; basemap [MAP].

Geoeconomics, technology and supply chains

Economic instruments can alter strategic choices

Instrument / trend	How India is affected	Useful response
Tariffs and industrial subsidies	Change relative costs, export access and investment location.	Negotiate access; improve competitiveness; help vulnerable sectors adjust.
Friend-shoring / China+1	Can redirect production toward India, but imported-input dependence may persist.	Build logistics, reliable power, skills and supplier networks.
Technology controls	Restrict access to chips, equipment, software or dual-use technology.	Diversify partnerships; support research, absorption and domestic capability.
Critical-mineral concentration	A producer/miner may differ from the refining or technology controller.	Diversify mining and processing, recycle, substitute and protect local consent.
Digital infrastructure / AI	Creates services and diplomacy opportunities; raises data, platform and compute dependence.	Interoperable systems, privacy, cybersecurity, local capacity and accountable standards.



Sovereign nationalism: answer the 2025 question

States seek greater control over borders, industry, technology and security. Trade rivalry, supply shocks and unequal gains from globalisation support this shift. Yet production, finance, climate and digital networks remain interconnected. The stronger judgement is **selective reorganisation of globalisation**, not its complete disappearance.

Two reusable examples

EU CBAM: climate regulation affects exporter costs and carbon-accounting requirements. India-US technology cooperation: strategic convergence can offer capability opportunities, while controls and domestic capacity still set limits.

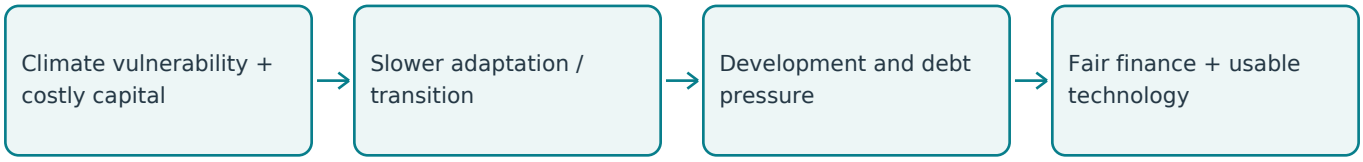
Recall: Why might a factory moving to India fail to reduce India's strategic dependence? Think of components, machinery and know-how.

[CBAM], [US25], [US26], [Q24], [Q25].

Energy, climate and the Global South

Development needs shape the terms of cooperation

Lens	Usable argument
Traditional energy security	Diversify suppliers and routes; build storage; improve efficiency; protect sea lanes. Affordable reliable energy remains a development need.
Energy transition	Renewables reduce some fuel exposure but create demand for minerals, batteries, grids and technology. Manage new concentrations of dependence.
Climate equity	Historical responsibility, different capacities and development needs support fair finance and technology access alongside domestic action.
Global South voice	Debt, food, health, digital access and adaptation link many developing countries; their interests are not identical.



Three precise anchors

India submitted its 2031-2035 NDC in April 2026: 47% lower GDP emissions intensity than 2005 and 60% non-fossil share of cumulative installed electric capacity by 2035. Net-zero is a 2070 goal. Installed capacity is not electricity generation.

COP29 (2024) set a finance goal of at least USD 300 billion a year by 2035, led by developed-country parties, within a wider scaling-up ambition. A target is not the same as disbursement.

A compact policy direction

Combine energy diversification with domestic clean capability; expand adaptation/resilient infrastructure cooperation; seek affordable finance and accessible technology; build South-South projects that deliver local benefits.

Useful examples: International Solar Alliance; Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure; African Union in G20. Explain what each instrument enables rather than merely naming it.

Recall: Give one reason climate ambition and energy security reinforce each other, and one reason they can create a trade-off.

[NDC26], [NDC-REG], [CLIMATE-FIN], [ISA], [CDRI], [G20].

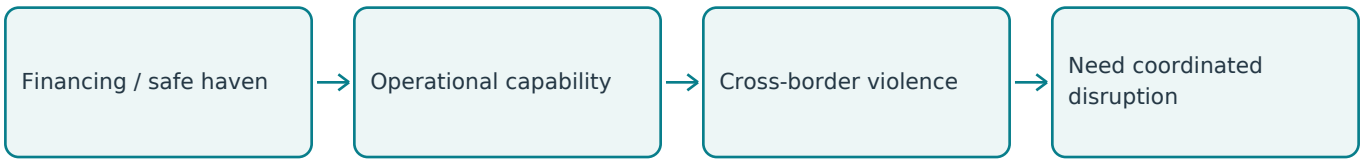
Conflict, terrorism and non-traditional security

Show transmission channels and matching instruments

Issue	Indian interest / transmission	Relevant response
Armed conflict	Energy/food prices, shipping, defence supplies, citizens abroad and diplomatic pressure.	Diplomatic channels; civilian assistance; consular readiness; diversified supplies.
Cross-border terrorism	Loss of life, escalation, trust deficit and reduced regional cooperation.	Intelligence/law-enforcement cooperation; finance controls; credible accountability; crisis communication.
Cyber / digital threats	Disruption to financial systems, public services and strategic infrastructure.	Resilient systems, trusted standards, incident sharing and trained institutions.
Water / climate risks	Floods, livelihood stress, displacement and interstate distrust.	Data sharing, early warning, ecological safeguards and negotiated arrangements.
Nuclear / arms control	Deterrence, escalation risk, technology access and non-proliferation disputes.	Risk reduction, secure command systems and credible diplomatic communication.

CTC effectiveness: four evaluation criteria

Coverage: do obligations reach emerging threats? **Capacity:** can states implement them? **Cooperation:** are information and assistance shared? **Consistency:** are standards applied without political selectivity?



The rights and legitimacy dimension

Counter-terror action is more sustainable when lawful, proportionate and accountable. Community trust improves information; indiscriminate action can undermine cooperation.

Distinctions: FATF standards differ from UN sanctions; nuclear power differs from nuclear weapons; being outside a treaty does not mean having no responsibilities; humanitarian engagement differs from endorsing every policy of a government.

Recall: Take one conflict headline and trace three separate effects on India before suggesting responses.

[CTC], [FATF], [UN-CHARTER]; [Q24].

Worked answers • IPMDA and BRICS

2026 Q9 and Q10 • two 150-word formats

IPMDA demand: explain the link, then critically assess it.

IPMDA connects the Quad's resources with India's cooperative maritime vision by improving partners' awareness of activity at sea.

The bridge: First, shared maritime information can help coastal states identify suspicious movements, illegal fishing and trafficking. Second, this supports safer sea lanes and coastal livelihoods, making regional security a public good. Third, information-centre cooperation and MAITRI training can strengthen local institutions rather than requiring external deployment.

The limits: Information alone cannot stop a vessel: partners need patrol capacity, legal authority and trained personnel. Data quality, confidentiality and willingness to share also affect results. Smaller states may hesitate if the initiative appears to require choosing sides.

India should therefore promote consent-based sharing, safeguards and coast-guard capacity alongside technology. IPMDA can operationalise SAGAR's cooperative purpose, provided regional partners gain usable capability and retain ownership of their security choices. Its success should be judged by effective response and partner trust, not information collection alone.

BRICS demand: explain its counterweight role without exaggeration

BRICS gives emerging economies a platform to influence global governance, though its effectiveness depends on converting shared demands into cooperation.

Its counterweight role: It amplifies calls for fairer representation in institutions such as the IMF and the UN. The New Development Bank adds infrastructure and sustainable-development finance, widening borrower options. South-South cooperation and the inclusion of new members broaden the forum's agenda and reach. Discussion of local-currency transactions also reflects concern about external financial vulnerabilities.

However, these functions do not make BRICS a unified geopolitical bloc. Members differ over security, trade and relations with Western countries. Expansion can complicate consensus, while financing capacity and project delivery constrain practical impact. A common currency should not be treated as an accomplished outcome.

For India, BRICS is most useful as a platform for institutional reform and development cooperation. Its strength lies in widening choices and bargaining voice rather than automatically replacing existing institutions.

Why these answers are structured this way

IPMDA: mechanism → public benefit → capacity/trust limits → priority. BRICS: voice → finance → wider reach → contradictions → judgement. Each retains the subject in every paragraph.

Original model answers; factual anchors: [QUAD], [BRICS], [NDB], [Q26].

Worked answer • BRI and South Asia

2026 Q20 • 250-word format • analytical route shown below

BRI has expanded China's infrastructure and financial presence in South Asia, increasing strategic competition around India. However, outcomes depend on project terms and host-country choices.

Implications for India's security

1. **Sovereignty:** CPEC passes through territory claimed by India, creating a direct objection to the initiative.
2. **Maritime exposure:** Chinese involvement in ports such as Gwadar and Hambantota raises concerns about surveillance and possible dual use near important routes. Commercial involvement should not automatically be equated with a military base.
3. **Strategic pressure:** transport, energy and digital infrastructure can strengthen China's regional access and create vulnerabilities during a crisis.

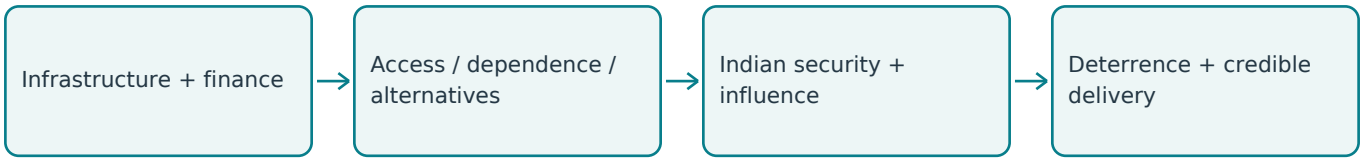
Implications for regional influence

4. **More alternatives:** neighbours gain financing options and bargaining space, reducing India's ability to rely on geographic proximity alone.
5. **Economic links:** infrastructure and commercial networks can shape standards, investment and long-term dependencies.
6. **Delivery competition:** India faces pressure to complete its own connectivity and development projects reliably.

Yet smaller states are not passive actors. They seek infrastructure and may renegotiate projects; debt stress has domestic and external causes. Describing every project as a deliberate debt trap oversimplifies these choices.

India's response should combine maritime awareness and credible deterrence with transparent finance, timely neighbourhood projects, regional power trade and diplomatic respect for sovereignty. Project assessment must examine viability, local benefits and actual access conditions.

India should compete by offering trusted, useful partnerships while protecting security interests. Durable influence depends on a neighbour's confidence in India's delivery and respect, alongside India's own capabilities.



Thinking before writing

Underline **security** and **regional influence**. Generate three points for each. Add the neighbour's agency as a qualification. Use an Indian Ocean sketch with only the relevant ports if time permits.

This model focuses on South Asia. A long detour through every BRI project worldwide would reduce space for the two demands.

Original model answer; question: [Q26]; context: [CHINA], [IMEC].

Worked answer • Diaspora and influence

2026 Q19 • 250-word format

India's diaspora connects culture with economic and knowledge networks. These links can strengthen influence, but their strategic value is not automatic.

How the bridge works

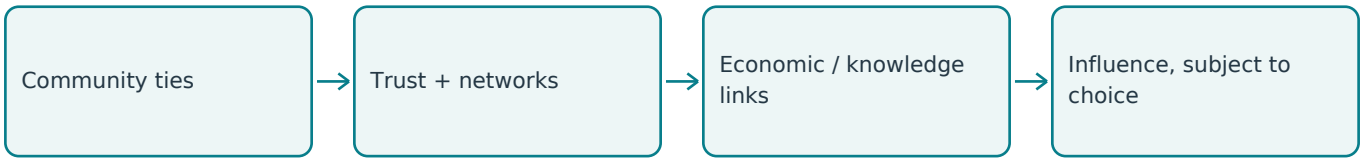
1. **Economic links:** India received about USD 138 billion in remittances in 2024 (World Bank). Entrepreneurs connect Indian firms with investment, markets and business advice.
2. **Knowledge networks:** professionals and researchers can support university cooperation, mentoring, innovation and access to skills.
3. **Cultural familiarity:** community institutions, languages, cinema and festivals create everyday contact, helping build trust and interest in India.
4. **Political access:** participation in public life and community advocacy can improve visibility for shared concerns and deepen people-to-people ties.
5. **Crisis support:** overseas associations can assist vulnerable migrants and help connect consulates with affected communities.

Why the conversion is limited

The diaspora differs across countries, generations and occupations. A Gulf worker, a technology entrepreneur and a long-settled citizen of another state have different needs and incentives. Shared ancestry does not determine political positions; elected representatives remain accountable to their own constituencies. Visa restrictions, discrimination, recruitment abuse and conflict can also expose migrants to harm. Brain drain may weaken domestic capacity if links with India remain shallow.

India should prioritise safe migration, responsive consular assistance and lower remittance costs. Research collaboration, transparent investment channels and skills networks can encourage engagement without expecting political loyalty.

The diaspora is therefore a potential source of attraction and capability. Its durable strategic contribution rests on reciprocal opportunity, protection and trust, together with respect for host-country sovereignty and individual choice.



How to generate the content

Separate **economic**, **knowledge**, **cultural** and **political** channels. Then ask who is excluded or vulnerable. A critical answer recognises both contributions and limits.

When adapting the answer, retain one dated figure and a clear knowledge-network example. Do not crowd the answer with numbers at the cost of explaining influence.

Original model answer; [Q26], [REMIT].

Worked answer • Why UN reform stalls

2025 Q20 • 250-word format

East-West confrontation obstructs UN reform by making institutional change part of strategic rivalry. Yet the stalemate also reflects representation disputes and difficult legal requirements.

How major-power confrontation blocks reform

First, permanent members are reluctant to dilute privileges or support changes that may favour rivals. Second, disputes over Ukraine and sanctions undermine trust needed for institutional bargains. Third, competing ideas of sovereignty, intervention and international order make agreement on the Council's future role difficult. Strategic competition can turn even procedural questions into bargaining instruments.

Why this is not the whole explanation

Developing countries also disagree over who should gain permanent or elected seats. Regional competitors resist particular candidates, while African demands concern both representation and the terms of membership. Proposals differ over veto rights, Council size and accountability. Moreover, positions within both the West and the wider developing world are not identical: a simple two-bloc picture hides important differences.

The Charter adds a high barrier. Article 108 requires adoption by two-thirds of the General Assembly and ratification by two-thirds of UN members, including all permanent Security Council members. A large diplomatic majority therefore cannot by itself secure amendment.

India's approach should combine advocacy for representative expansion with cooperation with G4 and African partners. Working-method reforms, greater transparency and more consistent implementation can improve effectiveness while wider negotiations continue.

The UN's legitimacy and effectiveness must advance together. Reform needs a coalition addressing underrepresentation as well as a bargain among existing powers; treating rivalry as the sole obstacle would miss both requirements.

Why the judgement is stronger

It addresses the statement's East-West claim and then tests its adequacy. It adds regional rivalries, competing models and the precise Charter procedure, instead of repeating "veto" in every point.

Visual option: a four-spoke hub: great-power rivalry / regional competition / legal threshold / design disagreements → reform deadlock.

Original model answer; [UN108], [UN-REF], [Q25].

Worked answer • India-Africa digital ties

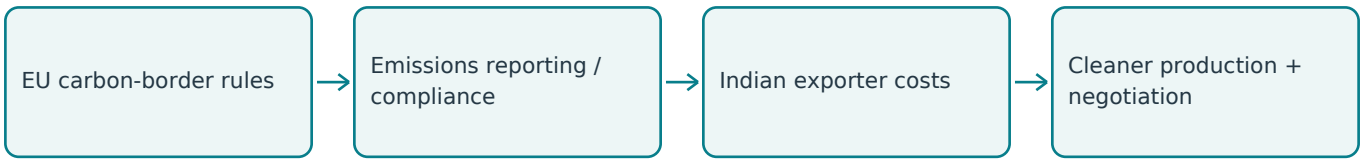
2025 Q9 • 150-word format + a reusable policy-impact drill

India-Africa digital cooperation can build a partnership when systems develop local capability and respond to priorities identified by African partners.
Mutual respect: co-design lets countries retain ownership over public services and data, rather than importing a fixed model. Systems must reflect languages, connectivity and administrative needs.
Co-development: training and adaptation enable universities, health agencies and domestic firms to operate and improve technology. The e-VidyaBharati/e-ArogyaBharati initiative provides an education-and-health cooperation example.
Institutional ties: collaboration among public agencies and educational institutions can outlast a single equipment contract and support knowledge exchange.
However, weak connectivity, cybersecurity risks, scarce technical staff and recurring maintenance costs may limit outcomes. Digital dependence can increase if control remains outside the partner country.
India should therefore combine accessible technology with skills, safeguards, local procurement opportunities and support. Success should be measured by services people can use and institutions can maintain, not by the number of announced projects.

Breakdown of the question

Phrase in the demand	What it asks you to demonstrate
Mutual respect	Ownership, consent and local priorities.
Co-development	Capacity to adapt and improve systems, not only purchase them.
Long-term institutions	Durable links, trained staff and maintenance beyond a launch.

Apply Framework 2 to a different issue: CBAM



Outline: explain the measure briefly; identify affected exports and data burdens; consider incentives for cleaner industry; add fairness and trade concerns; propose verification support, technology upgrading and diplomatic engagement.

What transfers between the answers?

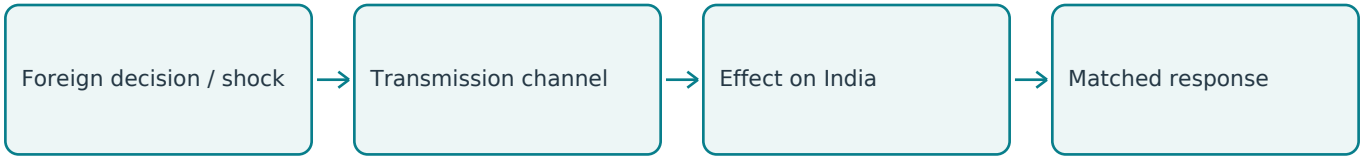
The content changes, but the habit stays: identify the actor, explain the mechanism, show who benefits or bears costs, and propose a response matched to the bottleneck.

Original model answer; [AF-DIG], [Q25], [CBAM].

A small visual library for the exam

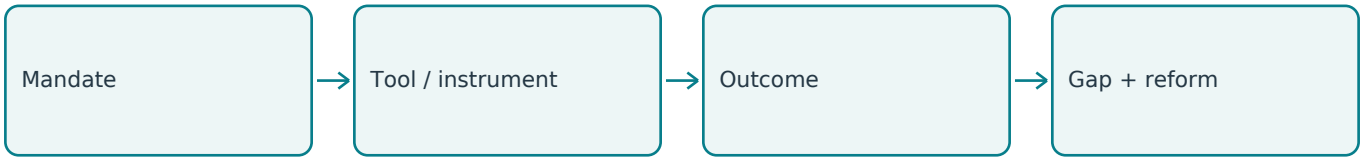
Choose a visual that explains a relationship

1. External event → Indian impact



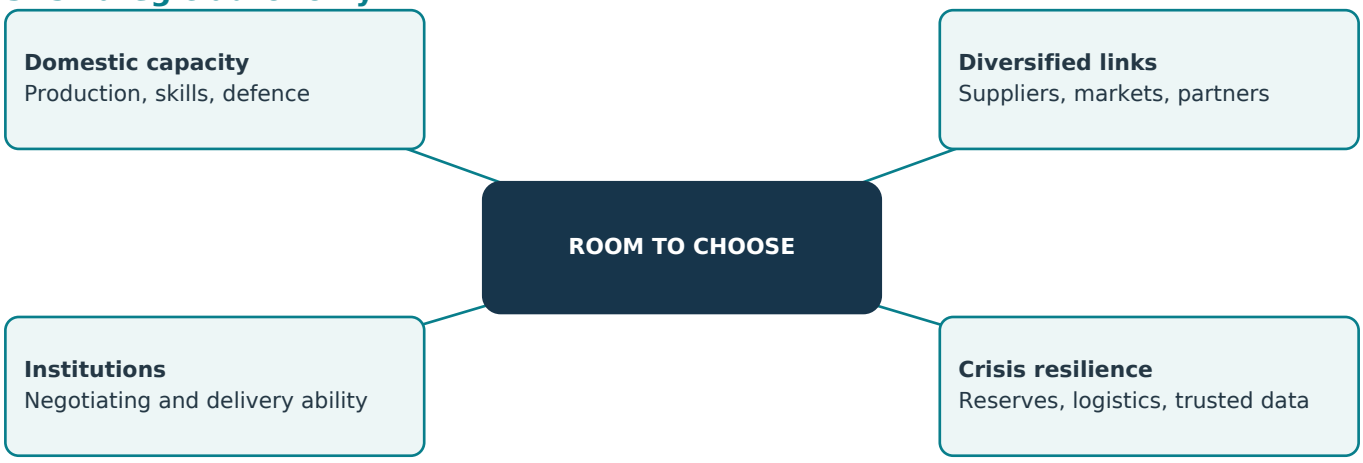
Use for sanctions, tariffs, wars, migration rules or shipping disruption. Label the channel: price, access, finance, technology or people.

2. Institution performance



Use for WHO, IMO, CTC or WTO. Put the actual convention, assessment or financing instrument in box 2.

3. Strategic autonomy



4. A comparison saves space

Draw a 3-row table using the same criteria: purpose / mechanism / limitation. Useful for SAARC-BIMSTEC, Quad-AUKUS and IMF-World Bank.

5. A map has a job

Mark only 3-5 locations and one relationship. Example: port → sea lane → Indian trade interest. A large map with no analytical labels consumes answer space. Aim to reproduce it in 30-45 seconds.

Avoid: decorative flags, uncertain borders, unlabelled arrows, overcrowded spokes and diagrams that repeat the paragraph word for word.

Minimum facts and current anchors

Memorise few facts, but label year, unit and status

Anchor	Use it for	Keep this distinction
UNSC: 15 members; 5 permanent	Representation and veto debate.	Not all UN bodies have the same powers.
Article 108: two-thirds + ratification, including P5	Why UN reform is hard.	A General Assembly majority alone does not amend the Charter.
India: about USD 138 bn remittances in 2024; World Bank WDI discussion, Aug 2026	Diaspora's economic channel.	Revised calendar-year series, not an RBI fiscal-year total.
India: close to USD 4 bn assistance to Sri Lanka in 2022	First response / neighbourhood trust.	A dated crisis response, not a current annual-aid figure.
IPMDA launched 2022; MAITRI announced 2024	Practical maritime cooperation.	Awareness and training are distinct from enforcement capability.
ASEAN: 11th member Timor-Leste, Oct 2025	Regional architecture; update old copies.	Full membership differs from an observer category.
BIMSTEC: Bangkok Vision 2030, Apr 2025	Project-based regionalism.	Adoption/signing differs from implementation.
EU-India FTA negotiations concluded Jan 2026	Trade and strategic diversification.	Do not automatically describe it as in force.
CBAM definitive phase: Jan 2026	Climate-trade linkage.	Rules, sector coverage and payment obligations need specific checking.
India 2035 NDC: 47% intensity reduction vs 2005; 60% non-fossil installed capacity	Climate policy and equity.	Targets are not achievements; capacity is not generation.
WHO Pandemic Agreement adopted May 2025; PABS talks continued July 2026	Global-health governance gap.	Adoption does not establish full operational readiness.

Weekly update rule: keep one new official example for each theme. Replace an old example only when the new one proves the argument more clearly. Avoid accumulating a long list of summit dates.

[UN108], [UN-VOTE], [REMIT], [LANKA], [QUAD], [ASEAN], [BIM25], [EU26], [CBAM], [NDC26], [WHO26].

A 21-day IR preparation cycle

Designed to sit alongside your GS classes and Maths practice

Use about 75-90 minutes a day: learn/revise for 30 minutes, retrieve for 15, draw for 5, and outline or write for 25-40. Adjust volume to your class subject and test schedule.

Days	Focus	Daily output
1-3	Frameworks; China; Pakistan/Afghanistan.	One closed-book recall card each day + one 150-word answer on day 3.
4-6	Bangladesh/Myanmar; Nepal/Bhutan; Sri Lanka/Maldives.	A neighbourhood map + 3 interests, 3 problems and 3 responses per pair.
7	Neighbourhood retrieval and writing.	Two unseen outlines + one 250-word answer. Correct the weakest demand.
8-10	US/Russia; Europe/Japan/Australia; Act East/West Asia.	One comparison table and one policy-impact chain per day.
11-12	Central Asia; Africa/Latin America/Pacific.	One access map + one development-partnership answer.
13-14	Quad/AUKUS; BRICS/SCO/G20; SAARC/BIMSTEC.	Three comparison tables; one 150-word and one 250-word answer.
15-17	UN; trade/finance institutions; WHO/UNESCO/IMO/CTC.	For each body: mandate, instrument, result, gap, reform.
18-19	Diaspora; technology, climate, energy and conflict.	One diaspora outline + three headline-to-impact drills.
20	Mixed test: 2 × 10 marks + 2 × 15 marks.	50 marks in about 36 minutes; evaluate coverage before adding content.
21	Repair and final recall.	Rewrite weakest answer; reproduce 4 maps/diagrams; finish a two-page personal summary.

Revisit the same card

Day 1 → Day 3 → Day 7 → Day 14 → Day 21. Recall first, then check. If blank, use the six prompts: place, flows, interests, risks, constraints, response.

Do not restart the whole chapter after a missed day. Continue from the next unit and use the review days to close the gap.

PRACTICE

Practice and potential 2027 extensions

Original practice prompts • not PYQs or predictions

Practice prompt	Thinking route
1. Can India's neighbourhood policy succeed through infrastructure finance alone? (150 words)	Delivery benefits → trust/sovereignty → institutions/local agency.
2. Maritime information-sharing is useful only when partners can act on it. Discuss. (150)	Awareness → enforcement capacity → consent and safeguards.
3. Critical-mineral security is as much a processing problem as a mining problem. Examine for India. (250)	Value chain → concentration → environmental/local consent → diversification.
4. Expanding BRICS strengthens representation while complicating effectiveness. Discuss. (150)	Voice/finance → diverse interests → design and delivery.
5. Connectivity corridors require political and regulatory integration as much as construction. Examine. (250)	Routes → customs/finance → conflict → project viability.
6. How should India reconcile strategic autonomy with deeper technology partnerships? (250)	Capability gains → external controls/dependence → domestic absorption.
7. Climate rules can reshape international trade. Assess India's options. (250)	CBAM mechanism → costs/clean incentives → equity → targeted response.
8. Diaspora engagement should begin with protection and opportunity. Discuss. (150)	Diverse migrants → welfare → economic/knowledge networks → influence.

A compact self-evaluation score, out of 10

Demand coverage 3 • explanation/cause-effect 2 • relevant examples 2 • qualification and judgement 2 • clarity/word discipline 1. This is a practice rubric, not an official UPSC marking scheme.

Your recall card

Theme: ___ | PYQ demand: ___
3 Indian interests: ___ | 3 examples: ___
2 friction points: ___ | 2 feasible responses: ___
1 diagram: ___ | Last recall: ___ | What I missed: ___

Priority areas for extension: maritime capacity, economic security, technology/AI governance, climate-trade rules, neighbourhood trust and institutional delivery. These follow recurring reasoning tasks and verified developments; they are not assurances about the next paper.

How the guide was checked

Evidence, interpretation and updates are kept distinct

PYQs

The demand map contains 61 core IR questions from 2013-2026: 8 in 2013, 5 in 2014 and 4 in each year from 2015 onward. It excludes mainly domestic-governance and comparative-constitution questions. This is a stated classification, not an official UPSC topic count.

The official 2025 and 2026 papers were read directly, including the scanned English text. Earlier questions were cross-checked using yearly transcriptions and a topic index, with official papers consulted where accessible. Some older official PDFs could not be retrieved in this session. The table therefore uses paraphrased demands and provides source routes for checking exact wording.

One indexing error was corrected: the IMF/World Bank question in 2013 is Q25, not Q20. The 2025 energy question is framed around coming years; no unsupported fixed 15-year period is imposed.

Topper copies

Two ForumIAS MGP GS II coaching practice copies were downloaded and visually inspected. Observations refer to the specific question/page ranges listed earlier. They are not actual UPSC evaluated answer scripts. No inference about a guaranteed score follows from their layout.

Content and current affairs

Institutional mandates and dated factual anchors use official/government/intergovernmental sources where available. Recommendations, frameworks and model answers are teaching synthesis. Country notes are analytical revision modules; they are not claims that every current diplomatic development has been covered.

Maps

Natural Earth public-domain land shapes provide geographic context. These are coast-only maps without international boundaries. Dots and routes are schematic; route completion, military access or legal status should not be inferred from a line or location marker.

Keep this guide current

Before a test: verify any live tariff/treaty/conflict claim; check membership and agreement status; label data by year; add one official example only if it improves your argument. Keep the permanent framework and update the factual layer.

All source links below were consulted or used as official source routes on 2 November 2026. Links to older papers/briefs may describe historical circumstances.

Source directory • 1

Click a source title to open the original

[Q] UPSC official question-paper portal
www.upsc.gov.in

[Q13] 2013 GS II: yearly transcription, IAS Exam Portal
iasexamportal.com

[Q14] 2014 GS II: official UPSC paper
www.upsc.gov.in

[Q15] 2015 GS II: official UPSC paper
www.upsc.gov.in

[Q16] 2016 GS II: official UPSC paper
www.upsc.gov.in

[Q17] 2017 GS II: yearly transcription, UPSC Grade
upscgrade.com

[Q18] 2018 GS II: yearly transcription, UPSC Grade
upscgrade.com

[Q19] 2019 GS II: yearly transcription, UPSC Grade
upscgrade.com

[Q20] 2020 GS II: yearly transcription, UPSC Grade
upscgrade.com

[Q21] 2021 GS II: yearly transcription, UPSC Grade
upscgrade.com

[Q22] 2022 GS II: yearly transcription, UPSC Grade
upscgrade.com

[Q23] 2023 GS II: yearly transcription, UPSC Grade
upscgrade.com

[Q24] 2024 GS II: yearly transcription, UPSC Grade
upscgrade.com

[Q25] 2025 GS II: official UPSC paper
www.upsc.gov.in

[Q26] 2026 GS II: official UPSC paper
www.upsc.gov.in

[IDX] InclusiveIAS: topic index, used for discovery/classification
inclusiveias.com

[T1] Ruhani: ForumIAS MGP GS II practice copy (2023)
forumias.com

Source directory • 2

Click a source title to open the original

[T2] Kunal Rastogi: ForumIAS sample MGP GS II copy (2023)
forumias.com

[CONST] Constitution of India: Legislative Department text
www.legislative.gov.in

[GUJ] I K Gujral: five principles in his 1997 address
www.stimson.org

[MEA] MEA annual report 2024: historical baseline, published 2025
www.mea.gov.in

[CHINA] Akashvani: MEA briefing on Depsang/Demchok, Nov 2024
newsonair.gov.in

[IWT] Official Indian statement: IWT position, 31 Aug 2026
eoibelgrade.gov.in

[AFG] Akashvani: Kabul mission restored to embassy, Oct 2025
newsonair.gov.in

[BAN] MEA: India-Bangladesh bilateral brief, 2024 baseline
www.mea.gov.in

[BRAHMA] PIB: Operation Brahma relief, 30 Mar 2025
www.pib.gov.in

[NEPAL] Embassy of India: India-Nepal relationship brief
www.indembkathmandu.gov.in

[BHUTAN] Embassy of India: India-Bhutan relationship brief
indembthimphu.gov.in

[POWER24] Ministry of Power annual report 2024-25
powermin.gov.in

[LANKA] Indian High Commission: crisis assistance, Sep 2022
www.hcicolombo.gov.in

[MAL] India-Maldives economic/maritime vision, Oct 2024
www.pmindia.gov.in

[IOR-COM] Parliament: Evaluation of Indian Ocean Strategy, 2025
eparlib.sansad.in

[MAHA] Indian mission article: SAGAR to MAHASAGAR
www.hcinicosia.gov.in

[US25] India-US joint statement, Feb 2025
www.pmindia.gov.in

Accessed 2 November 2026. Historical sources are labelled.

Source directory • 3

Click a source title to open the original

[US26] US-India joint statement: trade framework, Feb 2026
www.whitehouse.gov

[RUS25] India-Russia annual summit statement, Dec 2025
www.pmindia.gov.in

[EU26] European Council: EU-India summit, 27 Jan 2026
www.consilium.europa.eu

[EU-TEXT] European Commission: FTA texts and legal-status note
policy.trade.ec.europa.eu

[FR26] India-France joint statement: partnership upgrade, Feb 2026
www.pmindia.gov.in

[JPN25] India-Japan next-decade vision, Aug 2025
www.pmindia.gov.in

[ASEAN] ASEAN: Timor-Leste admitted as 11th member, Oct 2025
asean.org

[I2U2] PM India: I2U2 priority sectors, Jul 2022
www.pmindia.gov.in

[IMEC] Official IMEC memorandum of understanding, Sep 2023
www.mea.gov.in

[CHAB] Parliament reply: Chabahar operating contract, Nov 2024
sansad.in

[CA25] Tajik foreign ministry: India-Central Asia Dialogue, Jun 2025
www.mfa.tj

[AF-DIG] iLearn: e-VBAB programme for African students
www.ilearn.gov.in

[FIPIC] PIB: FIPIC III Summit, May 2023
www.pib.gov.in

[QUAD] PM India: 2024 Quad summit fact sheet, IPMDA/MAITRI
www.pmindia.gov.in

[AUKUS] UK government: AUKUS ministerial statement, May 2026
www.gov.uk

[IORA] Australian foreign ministry: IORA overview
www.dfat.gov.au

[BRICS] BRICS Brazilian presidency: purposes and participation
brics.br

Source directory • 4

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